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For the President
29 September 2026



Russia's Overnight Barrage on Kyiv Signals a Winter Coercion Campaign

We assess that Russia's large-scale overnight strikes on Kyiv reflect a deliberate shift toward a sustained winter campaign of combined ballistic-missile and long-range drone attacks intended to break Ukrainian will and infrastructure rather than to achieve a near-term battlefield breakthrough. We judge Moscow probably calculates that concentrated strikes on the capital and the grid will generate political pressure on Kyiv as cold weather sets in.

- The overnight assault killed at least seven people and wounded more than fifty, striking residential buildings, data centers, and the National Academy of Sciences in central Kyiv; Ukrainian officials reported roughly 170 drones launched alongside missiles.
- Ukrainian air defenses downed a Zircon/Oniks missile, two Iskander-M/S-400 ballistic missiles, and more than 100 drones, but saturation tactics again let some munitions through — a pattern we assess Russia will repeat through the winter.
- The Institute for the Study of War assesses that a Kremlin-affiliated figure is amplifying Putin's revised 'theory of victory,' betting that long-range strikes can compel capitulation over winter 2026-2027; we judge Putin likely seeks a decision before spring 2027.
- Ukrainian forces nonetheless made localized gains in the Chasiv Yar tactical zone and the Oleksandrivka direction, indicating the front has not broken despite the strikes.

Ukraine's own long-range campaign is biting: repeated drone strikes have driven Russian crude processing to its lowest level in more than two decades, forcing Moscow to restrict fuel exports and helping push global diesel prices sharply higher. Overhead imagery confirms sustained damage across several of Russia's largest refineries.

- The war continues to spill onto NATO's map: a drone — likely Russian — crossed into Romanian airspace overnight 26-27 September, part of a pattern of eastern-flank violations the Alliance has called reckless.
- For Washington, the near-term question is whether to accelerate deliveries of Patriot and NASAMS interceptors before the heaviest strikes arrive; a decision point also looms on further energy-sector sanctions to compound the refining squeeze.

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Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NSA, NGA, and open sources.

For the President
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Gaza Ceasefire Frays as Israel Kills a Senior Hamas Commander

We assess the Gaza ceasefire is eroding at the margins and that Israel's decision to kill a senior Hamas commander signals Jerusalem is preparing the ground for a possible expanded operation should the truce collapse. We judge Hamas's continued consolidation of control in the areas it holds is the primary driver of Israeli concern.

- The IDF said it killed Izz al-Din al-Bik, described as commander of Hamas's Northern Gaza Brigade, in a Gaza City airstrike, and separate strikes Monday killed at least two more Palestinians in Gaza City and the Nuseirat camp.
- Gaza health officials say roughly 1,400 Palestinians, mostly civilians, have been killed since the ceasefire took effect; the Israeli military reports four soldiers killed in the same period.
- Israeli security officials increasingly describe an expanded military operation as a possible foregone conclusion as Hamas tightens its grip on the population it governs.

For Washington, the risk is to the US-brokered ceasefire architecture. We expect the administration will press both sides to hold the truce; the decision point comes if Israel judges Hamas's reconstitution intolerable and returns to major operations, which would reopen the humanitarian and diplomatic crises the ceasefire was meant to close.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, INR, and open sources.

For the President
29 September 2026



Mass Settler Violence in the West Bank Tests Israeli Rule of Law

We judge the overnight settler rampage in the West Bank, and the unusually sharp cross-government condemnation it drew, reflect deepening strain within Israel over settler impunity — a dynamic with implications for Israeli internal stability and for US-Israel friction as the country moves toward elections.

- More than 100 settlers rioted in the Palestinian village of Jalud, torching homes and vehicles, blocking a family's return, and clashing with Israeli security forces; five people were arrested.
- Prime Minister Netanyahu and Defense Minister Katz condemned the 'rioters' as unrepresentative of settlers, while President Herzog called the violence 'a moral stain'; regional settlement leader Yisrael Ganz broke ranks to demand equal enforcement of the law.
- Separately, police arrested 11 people after Jewish youths assaulted Arab men near Damascus Gate in Jerusalem overnight, underscoring rising intercommunal violence.

For Washington, persistent settler violence complicates support for Israel and feeds international pressure. With Knesset elections expected on 27 October, we assess Netanyahu is balancing condemnation of the riots against reliance on a far-right base that includes pro-settlement ministers — a tension likely to sharpen through the campaign.

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UK Bails Suspects in Alleged Plot Near US-Used Air Base, Probes Iran Link

We assess the alleged plot near RAF Fairford underscores a persistent threat to US and allied military infrastructure in Europe. British investigators are examining a possible Iranian nexus; if confirmed, we judge it would mark a notable escalation of Iran-linked activity on UK soil, though the case against the suspects appears not yet fully established.

- Five British men, aged 23 to 25 and from the London area, were detained early Sunday after three vans were spotted near RAF Fairford — a UK base long used by US bombers — and were released on bail Monday under what police called stringent conditions while the investigation continues.
- Counter Terrorism Policing said it is pursuing multiple lines of inquiry, including whether there is a link to Iran; Britain's PA news agency reported, without citing sources, that no viable explosives were found.
- Fairford has hosted US strategic bomber operations during past Middle East campaigns, making it a symbolically and operationally significant target.

For Washington, an established Iranian tie would fit a broader pattern of Iran-linked plots and surveillance across Europe and would raise questions for force protection at US-used facilities. We expect UK charging decisions and any attribution to take weeks; the near-term watch item is whether investigators can substantiate the Iran lead.

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Sweden Moves To Install a Center-Left Government Under Andersson

We assess Sweden is on the cusp of a government handover to Magdalena Andersson's center-left bloc following its narrow election win. We judge the transition will preserve Stockholm's strong support for Ukraine and its commitments as a new NATO member, while shifting domestic, migration, and fiscal policy — but that a razor-thin majority makes for a fragile government.

- The newly elected Riksdag convened 28 September; a formal parliamentary vote confirming a prime minister could come as early as 29 September, with Andersson the leading contender after outgoing Prime Minister Kristersson resigned.
- Andersson's four-party bloc holds 176 of 349 seats to the outgoing center-right government's 173 — a three-seat margin.
- Government formation is contested: the Centre Party opposes cabinet posts for the Left Party, which Andersson has also ruled out from cabinet while seeking its support in parliament.

For the United States, Sweden's continuity on defense spending and Ukraine matters given its 2024 NATO accession and its position in the Baltic. We expect no near-term break in alignment, but a slim majority raises the odds of legislative gridlock and an early test of the coalition's durability.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from INR and open sources.

For the President
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Khartoum Presses the UN on the RSF's Foreign Backers as Darfur Atrocities Mount

We assess Sudan's appeal at the UN General Assembly is aimed at reframing the war around external sponsorship of the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces — the factor Khartoum argues is decisive. We judge the RSF's consolidation in Darfur, coupled with documented atrocities, points to a deepening humanitarian catastrophe with limited near-term prospects for resolution.

- Sudan's foreign minister, Mohieddin Salim, told the General Assembly on 28 September, speaking for Sovereign Council head Abdel Fattah al-Burhan, that halting external support to the RSF is the only viable path to peace; Burhan was barred from attending after the United States declined to issue him a visa.
- The RSF has held El Fasher, the army's last Darfur stronghold, since October 2025; rights organizations have documented ethnic cleansing and mass atrocities in the region.
- The visa denial highlights US leverage but also friction with Khartoum, even as Washington weighs pressure on Gulf partners alleged to back the RSF.

For Washington, the practical levers run through the RSF's external sponsors. We expect continued pressure for a humanitarian pause and possible additional sanctions; a decision point is whether the UN Security Council can move past the divisions that have stalled action.

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Notes

US-China. Post-summit assessments are hardening. The Trump-Xi meeting yielded only a shorter-than-expected roughly two-month tariff-truce extension and an agreement to form an agricultural-trade working group, with no breakthrough on the advanced technologies both sides most contest. A US official assessed that Xi made little progress, and Beijing's push to curb US arms sales to Taiwan gained no traction. We judge the underlying rivalry is unresolved and the truce fragile.

Taiwan. Taipei's Mainland Affairs Council reported on 28 September that four more Taiwanese were detained, reported missing, or had their movement restricted in China over the past week, bringing the total since January 2024 to 449. We assess Beijing is using detentions as a coercive tool against Taipei.

Russia's energy squeeze. Ukraine's expanded long-range strikes have driven Russian oil refining to a multi-decade low, prompting Moscow to curb exports of gasoline, diesel, and jet fuel to protect domestic supply. The knock-on effects are reaching US consumers, with diesel prices climbing. We expect Kyiv to sustain the campaign as a strategic pressure point.

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